

Apply to be a Science Corps Fellow - Entry #3403

Name
Sabrina Marcelo
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Gender
Female
Residence: City (State), Country
Melbourne, Australia
Nationality
USA
When did you or do you expect to complete your PhD?
June-December, 2026
Please tell us briefly about your university education (institution, city, country, year)
I am currently completing a PhD in Physics at the University of Melbourne (Melbourne, Australia), expected to finish in 2026. I previously completed an MSc in Physics at McGill University (Montreal, Canada) in 2022, and a BA in astrophysics at the University of California, Berkeley in 2018.
Why would you like to be a Science Corps Fellow?
The Science Corps Fellowship will allow me to contribute to equitable STEM education around the world in a way that closely aligns with both my personal background and values. I've gone through my scientific career so far always trying to uplift other scientists from underrepresented backgrounds through mentorship and teaching opportunities. As a second-generation Filipina immigrant in the USA, I have long wanted to give back to the Philippines, specifically, and to contribute in a way that is sustainable rather than extractive or short term. The Science Corps' model of embedding STEM PhDs within schools to teach and build local capacity reflects the kind of engagement I value most. I want to work alongside educators and students and adapt to local needs. I would like to leave behind tools and resources that continue to serve the community beyond the fellowship period. I am also drawn to Science Corps because it offers STEM PhDs the opportunity to step outside the traditional academic pipeline and actively expand access to science for those who may not otherwise have had the opportunity to enter it. I grew up never imagining that I could become a scientist. Teaching in the Philippines would allow me to help encourage students to enter science who, like I once did, may not have seen themselves represented in or welcomed by the field.

I see this experience as formative not only for the students I would work with, but also for my own growth as a scientist. One of my main goals as a scientist is to increase access to quality STEM education to everyone and this fellowship would allow me to do just that.

In addition to your studies, please describe any prior experience that may help you as a Science Corps Fellow.

I am deeply committed to building inclusive and accessible scientific communities. From 2022–2025, I co-hosted and managed astro[sound]bites (<https://astrosoundbites.com/>), the podcast spinoff of astrobites.org, which has reached over 30,000 listeners worldwide. Across 36+ episodes (50+ hours), I translated cutting-edge astrophysics research into an engaging and conversational format for broad audiences. I also co-led episodes addressing equity and wellbeing in science, including community college pathways to astronomy, Indigenous astronomy, and mental health in academia.

Mentorship has always been especially important to me as I've progressed through science so far. Since 2020, I have mentored 15 students in research and professional development. My mentees include a current PhD student at the University of Washington and a former undergraduate who co-authored one of my first author papers and is now applying to graduate school with my guidance.

I have founded and organized multiple scholarly communities. In 2024, I founded the Black Hole Journal Club at my university, now in its second year with 25 weekly participants. An attendee recently called it "my favorite part of the week -- a fun and inclusive place to learn about new research". Previously, I co-founded the Machine Learning in Astrophysics Journal Club at McGill University, fostering interdisciplinary discussion at the intersection of AI and astronomy.

I have also worked to improve mental health literacy in academia. As Mental Health Officer for the McGill Graduate Association of Physics, I secured departmental funding to organize a speaker series where physicists shared lived experiences, and I helped expand access to wellbeing resources during the COVID-19 pandemic.

My teaching experience includes instructing Python programming to over 150 women and non-binary students through a software engineering bootcamp. I have also been a teaching assistant for seven semesters of physics and computing undergraduate and graduate courses across three universities, emphasizing inclusive and active learning pedagogies.

Finally, I have organized international conferences and hackathons, delivered nine outreach talks across three countries, and completed formal science communication training through multiple programs. Collectively, these experiences have equipped me with the teaching and mentorship skills to contribute meaningfully as a Science Corps Fellow.

Where do you imagine yourself professionally in the future? Check all that apply.

Scientist in academia

Please expand on your selection above and describe where you imagine yourself professionally in the near (~2 year) and long-term (~10 year) future.

In the near term (approximately 2 years), I imagine myself in a postdoctoral research position where I am actively contributing to scientific discovery while also mentoring students from diverse backgrounds. I hope to be part of a collaborative research environment that values both research and mentorship excellence, where I can support students not only in developing research skills but also in navigating the often opaque academic pipeline. I see mentorship, teaching, and community building as integral to my role as a scientist rather than as peripheral activities.

In the longer term (approximately 10 years), I envision myself as a faculty member leading a research group doing exciting research on the early Universe while maintaining an inclusive and supportive culture. I aim to build a lab where students from a wide range of backgrounds can thrive and are supported by mentorship that recognizes that there is no single path to success in science. Beyond research, I hope to remain engaged in efforts that broaden participation in STEM and lower barriers to entry. I see my long term career as one that combines scientific leadership with a sustained commitment to equity and mentorship.

The Science Corps experience is central to this vision as it will allow me to grow as an educator and better understand how science education can be made more accessible across different cultural contexts.

Please upload your CV (.pdf)

 [CV_Sabrina_Berger_Marcelo.pdf](#)

How did you find out about Science Corps?

Referred by a friend/colleague/supervisor in academia

[Science Corps](#)